

ITALO BALBO

LIKE THOUSANDS OF OTHER disillusioned young men who fought for Italy in World War I, Italo Balbo (1896–1940) joined Mussolini's violent Fascist Blackshirts in the early 1920s, playing a prominent part in Mussolini's rise to power. In 1929, he was appointed head of Italian aviation.

Only then did he learn to fly. In 1928, Balbo became famous beyond Italy's frontiers for the mass-formation flights he staged – 60 seaplanes across southern Europe in

DASHING PIONEER

As minister of aviation from 1929–33, Italo Balbo helped modernize Italian aviation, gaining it an international reputation with his mass-formation flights.

ITALIAN GLORY

This booklet, dedicated to the “Brave and Intrepid Italian Aviators... and Italo Balbo... who led the glory of Italian wings...,” celebrates their internationally acclaimed flight from Rome to Chicago.

1928; 10 seaplanes across the southern Atlantic to Brazil in 1931; and 24 seaplanes to Chicago in 1933. Jealous of the acclaim Balbo received for the Chicago flight, Mussolini then packed him off to govern the Italian colony of Libya. Balbo subsequently opposed Mussolini's alliance with Nazi Germany in 1939, proposing instead a rapprochement with Britain. He was killed in 1940 when his airplane was mistakenly shot down by an Italian anti-aircraft battery.



colonial conflicts. Faced with a rebellion in Afghanistan in 1919, the British bombed Kabul and Jalalabad, also dropping leaflets warning Afghani troops and tribesmen of the dire fate that awaited them if they did not surrender.

This had no appreciable effect. But the use of air power against rebels in Iraq between 1922 and 1925 was judged a major success, showing that the RAF could act as a cheap imperial policeman. France and Spain both used air power against Berber rebels led by Abd al-Karim in their respective colonies in Morocco in the 1920s – the French achieving particular success employing their aircraft in tactical support of mobile columns of troops in trucks and armored cars.

Symbols of power

Whatever the tactics employed and the practical results achieved, there was something profoundly satisfactory to the European psyche in the deployment of aircraft against “primitive” peoples. At a period when the unbridled assertion of white racial superiority and Western technological prowess was starting to be challenged by anti-colonial movements, aircraft stood as a

FASCIST FRIENDS

Italo Balbo (left) was the closest ally and heir-apparent of Benito Mussolini (right) until the acclaim following his transatlantic flights aroused Mussolini's jealousy. This photograph was taken in Italy in the mid-1930s.

